sealed their fellowship by drinking from the same cup; together, they would revive the name of the Timurids in their ancestral land.

Only months later, however, when Humayun set off for Balkh, Kamran reneged on his promise. And such was Kamran's reputation that when he didn't show up, Humayun's soldiers assumed he'd gone to Kabul instead, and began to desert. Or, as Gulbadan puts it, 'the royal army ran away'. Humayun was forced to abandon his campaign ('after a thousand struggles with his spirit'),[48] bitterly disappointed, and return to Kabul, where rumours of Kamran's renewed rebellion were proven false.

But what if Kamran had not played spoilsport – would the Mughals have had an Indian empire at all? Abul Fazl isn't sure, thanking God for the rumours and defections, if not for which 'the work of the helpless ones of India would have been hindered by the undertaking of the conquest of Transoxiana'.

Indeed, Humayun did not abandon Balkh easily. He tried to enlist Kamran's support once again, and once again Kamran replied obligingly and did nothing. Eventually, Humayun realized that he would have to battle his brother before he could battle Balkh – to stop him 'wandering about the country with bad intentions', as Jouher puts it – but he did not realize that the loyalty of his chiefs had sprung leaks again. They fed him incorrect intelligence, enabling Kamran to launch a surprise attack in which Humayun's soldiers were butchered, and Humayun injured. As he was led away from the carnage by a few faithful men, Humayun lost his *jubba* – a quilted, protective jacket that would propel a twist in the act to come.

The jubba was brought to Kamran's camp, and taken to imply Humayun's death. Kamran, so delighted that he 'could not contain himself', marched to Kabul, where he used the jacket to convince its governor that Humayun was no longer alive to assert any claim on the city.[49]

Humayun's son, on the other hand, was a different matter. Akbar wasn't a child any longer, to be allowed to play in court. He was eight years old, Humayun's sole heir, and potential anchor of any rebellion by Humayun's loyalists. Kamran put him in prison. How the news of his father's demise and his own imprisonment affected the boy isn't recorded. If he was grief-stricken and afraid, he may also have derived some comfort from knowing that his family's fortunes tended to see-saw with manic speed. True enough,